The German electors gathered, to the north, and immediately split into two camps. They named two kings simultaneously, Louis of Bavaria and Frederick of Austria. Immediately, civil war began; the two men were equal in supporters, in land, and in armies, and the civil war went on for a full decade.

Wary of Philip IV, deprived of German support, Clement now made overtures to the sole remaining strong power in Italy: the King of Naples. Charles the Lame had died in 1309, four years before, and his son Robert had succeeded him as king of southern Italy. Clement offered Robert the position Vicar of Italy, which meant vice-regent of the north, theoretically under papal authority. This was good for Robert, since it doubled the size of his kingdom; it was also good for Clement, since Robert directly owed him loyalty for the land.[16]

It was the last decision Clement made. He died on April 20, 1314, fifty years old, suffering from an illness that left ulcers all over his legs. His body was taken to Uzeste, where he had asked to be buried. While it was lying in state, says the Italian chronicler Agnolo di Tura, a fire burst out and burned the bottom half of the corpse, either a very bad stroke of luck or a folktale ending to the pope whose catastrophic rule had destroyed the Templars and taken the papacy into exile.[17]

Seven months later, the forty-six-year-old king of France was boar hunting on horseback in Fontainebleau forest when his horse fell, injuring him so badly that he died a few days later. His son Louis, who had already inherited the crown of Navarre from his mother Queen Joan at her death in 1305, now became king of France as well.

He ruled as king of France and Navarre for only eighteen months before dying unexpectedly at the age of twenty-seven. His second wife was about to give birth, and the nobles of France agreed to appoint Louis's younger brother Philip as regent, pending the baby's birth. On November 15, she gave birth to a son; but he lived for only six days.

Louis X already had a daughter, Princess Joan, from his first marriage. Her relatives attempted to argue that she, as the direct descendant of the oldest son, should become queen of France. Philip immediately had his lawyers dig out an ancient bit of law used by the barbarian Salian Franks, centuries before. The lawyers argued convincingly that this code, the Salic Law, had always been an acknowledged part of French law; and since it barred women from inheriting the rule, Princess Joan could inherit only the crown of Navarre from her dead father. The French throne had to go to the nearest male relative: Louis's brother.

The French nobles, on the whole, preferred to be ruled by a grown man